12

Going West

I returned to India in a thoughtful mood. I had confronted my past while in Pakistan and accepted the reality that I was the product of both countries —Pakistan was my childhood where I had learnt how to face hardships, India was my youth and adulthood that saw the fulfilment of my dreams.

After a few days in Delhi, I left for Germany as captain of India's athletic team. This was the first stop on a tour of Europe that extended from May to July 1960 and culminated with the Rome Olympics in August.

I was pleasantly surprised to discover how famous I was in Germany. My first race in Frankfurt was a friendly contest where I would be participating with one of their top athletes, Carl Kaufmann. When I was introduced to this splendid young man who later became a good friend of mine, he shyly told me, through an interpreter, that his countrymen believed that except for Milkha Singh, he had no equals in the world.

Typically, I was not in the best of spirits on the day of the contest. Perhaps I was still jet-lagged or had yet to get acclimatized to the weather. As a result, I lost the first race badly. My coach, Ranbir Singh, and teammates tried very hard to console me, but I was too humiliated by my defeat. I had never lost a 400-metre race till that day, so how could this happen?

Another contest was held at Cologne a few days later. I performed better this time and Kaufmann and I were tied for the first place. For me, this was as bad as being defeated. Then, it was announced that as a result of a photo finish, I had reached the tape before Kaufmann. My victory convinced Kaufmann that I was getting back into form and that it would be more prudent to avoid further contests. Another German ace sprinter,